evidence of her skills, had been born into a lowly barber's family. When he learnt that she was the daughter of a Brahman, and moreover of a Brahman who had given her to him as his wife, he promptly made her his chief wife and fulfilled her wish. Bindusara must have had many wives and some of them, this story suggests, were forgotten as soon as he married them. But in any case, having discovered that his barber was intended as his wife, and having installed her in that capacity, Bindusara made up for lost time. There was much dalliance and mutual enjoyment which resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Ashoka.

The same legend which describes how the Brahman girl from Champa fulfilled what had been prophesied also recounts that, when her son was born, it was she who named him. Apparently, when the infant's birth was being celebrated she was asked what his name should be, and since she replied that she had no sorrow, the child was given the name Ashoka (a-shoka: 'without sorrow').[28] She seems to have continued to remain fascinated with this name because subsequently, when a second son was born to her, this younger brother of Ashoka was named Vitashoka. This was because, as the legend puts it, when he was born, all 'sorrow ceased' ('vigate shoke').[29]

Moving on now to the second occasion where Ashoka's future, figuratively speaking, was reconfirmed, this happened some years later, by which time he was a young prince. Again, it is his mother who is prominent as a protagonist in this story, now along with a wandering Ajivika ascetic. The Ajivika link with Ashoka's mother, it will be later evident, also appears in a different form in another legend around his birth. Among the cast of characters who knew about Ashoka's 'coming', the mother and an Ajivika are common to both the stories.